

DECODED EXPLAINED

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A Growth Story That Needs Women at Work

A growth story that needs women at work

India aspires to become a developed country (**Viksit Bharat**) by 2047, yet youth unemployment is already double the rate of 2012. India, especially the government, may be forced to recognise the weaknesses of India's economy due to the West Asia war shock. However, weakness pre-dates this exogenous shock. Policy-induced shocks from 2016 (demonetisation, a poorly designed Goods and Services Tax, NBFCs, COVID-19 pandemic management) to the economy had already reversed structural change (rise in farm employment, falling manufacturing share of gross value added and in employment); non-farm job growth had slowed. The economy became more unequal, and hence aggregate demand collapsed, and with it investment/GDP ratio. So, GDP growth is much slower (even if government figures of 6.2% p.a. are believed (it is actually at best 4.5%, as the former Chief Economic Adviser recently argued)).

An engine of growth

Further, India's growth story will remain incomplete without increasing the **work participation rate (WPR)** of half the population, i.e., women. In a new study, we estimate that a 10-percentage-point increase in India's female WPR could add nearly two percentage points to GDP growth, making women's employment one of the strongest drivers of economic growth. To sustain rapid growth of 8%-9% and emerge as a global economic power, the nation must harness the immense potential of its youth, especially young women.

Increased female WPR could contribute to economic growth in multiple ways. First, it increases the overall labour supply, thereby expanding productive capacity. When more women enter paid employment, household incomes rise, consumption increases, and savings improve. Higher household incomes also lead to better nutrition, education, and healthcare for children, thereby strengthening long-term human capital. Women's work participation can also improve productivity and innovation. Based on cross-country evidence, Nobel laureate Claudia Goldin argues that gender-diverse workplaces are often more efficient, creative, and competitive. Including women in the workforce is not merely a welfare measure but also a strategy for enhancing national productivity.

However, the work participation rate (WPR) of women in India remains below 30% – among the lowest in the world, comparable to that of countries such as Saudi Arabia and Yemen and West Asia. India's **female labour force participation rate (LFPR)** is low by international



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Women's employment is essential for growth, productivity, and achieving Viksit Bharat goals

standards, even when compared with countries at similar levels of per capita income. Worse, it declined steadily between 1983 and 2018. As overall job growth in both the farm and non-farm sectors fell between 2012 and 2018, how did women fare? This is a critical question, especially since women are now much better educated than earlier.

Decline in women's work

In the 1980s and during the early 1990s, the WPR for women was high, primarily due to high participation in agricultural activities. However, this trend began to decline as economic growth and structural transformation led to a shift away from agriculture from 2004-05 to 2012. Many rural women withdrew from the workforce due to mechanisation and reduced demand for manual labour.

Fortunately, this period also saw a rise in educational attainment among young women, leading to increased school attendance. In other words, the Indian economy experienced a downward movement in female WPR in the first half of the U-shaped curve until 2018-19, consistent with the argument of Claudia Goldin.

Much has been made by government economists of the increase in women's work participation in India, post 2020. However, this increase built upon a GDP growth slowdown since 2017. Further, COVID-19 had induced economic distress, and large-scale return migration from urban to rural areas. With male workers losing urban employment and moving back to villages, women were compelled to intensify their role in subsistence agriculture and allied activities, often as unpaid family labour (UFL). This surge in UFL reflected a "distress-driven feminisation of agriculture", as women entered or remained in insecure, informal, and unremunerated agricultural work, due to shrinking non-farm opportunities and reinforced gender norms that limited mobility. The share of such work was falling from 1983 to 2012, as was the absolute number of women in such work. The collapse of non-farm work for men and women now meant that adult, poorly educated women returned to agriculture.

The structure of India's economic growth has also contributed to weak female employment generation. Much of India's recent GDP growth has been concentrated in capital-intensive sectors such as finance, information technology, and organised manufacturing, which do not absorb large numbers of workers. Labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, food processing, garments, and small-scale manufacturing saw a fall in absolute terms in employment between

2013 and 2019. In fact fewer women were employed in manufacturing in 2019 than in 2004 which shows how manufacturing jobs collapsed, despite all the hype about "Make in India" and Performance-Linked Incentives for manufacturing. It was not until 2022 that manufacturing work for women rose to a level found in 2004. In much of India, manufacturing, or women's work has not received sufficient policy support.

The north-south divide

We show that young girls' unemployment is much higher than for young men. However, there is a real north-south divide, as highlighted in the book, *India Out of Work*. What is achievable is demonstrated by Tamil Nadu, which has been one of India's fastest-growing States. More than 40% of India's women factory workers are employed in Tamil Nadu. This is remarkable, given that Tamil Nadu accounts for only about 5%-6% of India's population. This concentration is driven primarily by the State's strong presence in textiles and garments (especially in Tiruppur and Coimbatore), footwear, electronics assembly (Sriperumbudur), and automobiles and auto components, as well as by higher female literacy, greater mobility, and well-developed hostel and transport facilities for women workers.

Similarly, Hindi-belt States need to invest in the health (not insurance-based) and public education for all, especially of girls and women, to reduce higher-than-African level malnutrition and stunting rates – as the Southern states have done. They can then also see similar outcomes. There is no chance for India being 'Viksit' without gender equality in all dimensions, especially in north India.

Some increase of female WPR (who re-entered agriculture) across India since 2020 was due to older adult women engaging in animal husbandry and poultry farming – a welcome development for household incomes.

However, what about educated young girls?

The gross enrolment rate at the secondary level was universalised between 2010 and 2015, with gender parity achieved even in rural Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. However, educated young women face high and rising unemployment rates.

Worse, the number of young women (aged 15-29 years) who were neither looking for work nor in education, was under 70 million until 2004. It increased to 84 million in 2012 and then rose to over 100 million by 2018. Bihar's female WPR is only 15%. Hence, India will remain out of work, and cannot become a developed country by excluding half its population from productive employment.

A Growth Story That Needs Women at Work

Female Labour Force Participation Rate measures the share of women who are either working or actively seeking/available for work.

It includes:

- Employed women
- Unemployed women actively looking for work
- It does not include women who are outside the labour force, such as those only engaged in unpaid domestic work, full-time education, elderly care, childcare, or those not seeking work.

Formula

Female LFPR = Female labour force / Total female population × 100

Usually, it is measured for women aged 15 years and above.

According to the PLFS Annual Report 2025, female LFPR in usual status for persons aged 15 years and above stood at 40.0% in 2025, while male LFPR was 79.1%. Rural female LFPR was higher at 45.9%, showing that women's participation is much stronger in rural areas than in urban areas.

The Worker Population Ratio (WPR) is defined as the ratio of the total number of workers to the total population, expressed as a percentage.

Formula: Worker Population Ratio = (Total Number of Workers / Total Population) × 100.

A Growth Story That Needs Women at Work

● The Core Argument

- A new study estimates a 10-percentage-point increase in India's female Work Participation Rate (WPR) could add nearly two percentage points to GDP growth, making women's employment one of the strongest drivers of economic growth
- India's female WPR remains below 30% among the lowest in the world, comparable to Saudi Arabia, Yemen, and West Asia and it declined steadily between 1983 and 2018

● Why Women's Work Participation Fell

- In the 1980s and early 1990s, female WPR was high due to agricultural participation, but declined as growth and structural transformation shifted the economy away from agriculture from 2004-05 to 2012, with rural women withdrawing due to mechanisation and reduced demand for manual labour
- Post-2020 increases in women's work participation coincided with a GDP growth slowdown and COVID-19-induced economic distress; women were compelled to intensify unpaid family labour in subsistence agriculture, a “distress-driven feminisation of agriculture,” not genuine empowerment
- India's recent GDP growth has been concentrated in capital-intensive sectors such as finance, IT, and organised manufacturing that don't absorb large numbers of workers, while women's manufacturing employment actually fell between 2013 and 2019

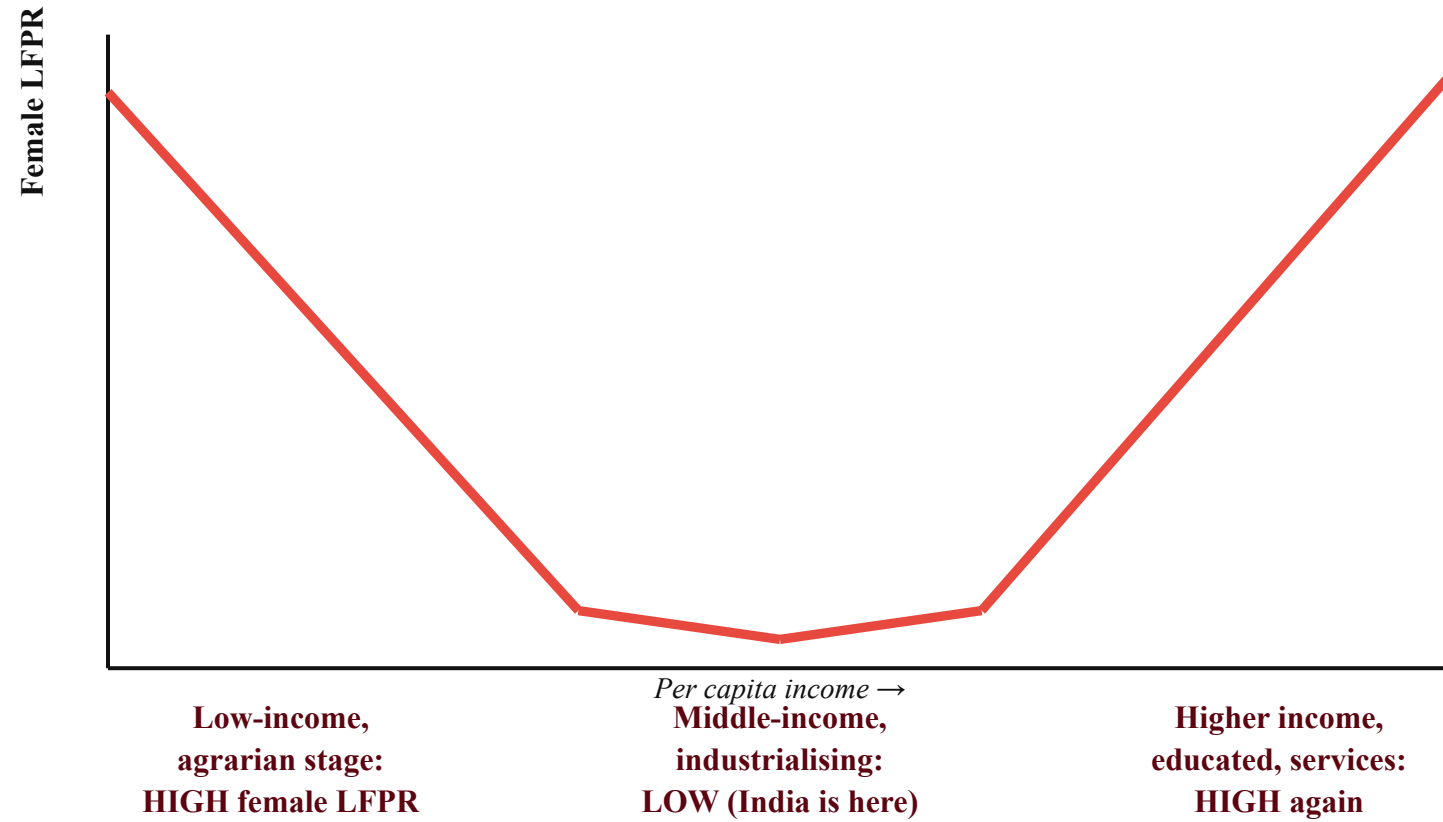
A Growth Story That Needs Women at Work

● The North-South Divide

- Young girls' unemployment is much higher than for young men, but there is a real north-south divide; Tamil Nadu, one of India's fastest-growing states, employs over 40% of India's women factory workers despite accounting for only 5-6% of India's population
- Tamil Nadu's concentration is driven by its strength in textiles and garments, footwear, electronics assembly, and automobiles, alongside higher female literacy, mobility, and hostel and transport facilities for women workers
- Hindi-belt states need to invest in health and public education for girls and women to reduce malnutrition and achieve similar outcomes, as Southern states have done

A Growth Story That Needs Women at Work

The U-Shaped Curve of Female Labour Force Participation



A Growth Story That Needs Women at Work

● The U-Shaped Female Labour Force Participation Curve

- Economist Claudia Goldin's theory holds that female LFPR is high at low-income, agrarian stages, dips during middle-income industrialisation, then rises again as income, education, and social norms evolve further
- India appears to be in the first half of this U-curve, the declining phase, consistent with Goldin's framework

● Feminisation of Agriculture

- Refers to women increasingly taking up agricultural work, often as unpaid family labour, as men migrate to non-farm or urban jobs, this can reflect either genuine shifts in gender roles or, as noted here, distress-driven coping during economic downturns

● Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS)

- India's primary official survey, conducted since 2017-18, for measuring employment, unemployment, and labour force participation, including gender-disaggregated data

Renewed War Erases Russian Oil Discounts

Renewed war erases Russian oil discounts

Sukalp Sharma

New Delhi, July 24

DISCOUNTS ON Russian oil for Indian refiners have vanished again amid the resurgence of conflict in West Asia and the sharp drop in energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, a senior official with government-owned refiner Bharat Petroleum Corporation (BPCL) has said.

Amid all this, the demand for oil from other regions has shot up once again, leading to erosion of discounts on Russian oil — the mainstay of India's oil imports.

BPCL's Director (Finance) Vetsa Ramakrishna Gupta said that while Indian refiners are not receiving any discount offer for Russian crude in the prevailing market conditions, there is ample availability of Moscow's oil and crude from other sources in the market to keep India well-supplied.

Given the tightness in global energy supplies, Indian refiners are prioritising oil supply security over price considerations.

As for the US allowing its sanctions waiver on Russian oil purchases to lapse, Gupta said that the move has had no notable impact on buying behaviour as there are enough non-US-sanctioned suppliers of

Russian oil in the market.

The sanctions waiver, which was issued by the US to keep the global oil market well-supplied, lapsed on June 17, the same day on which the US-Iran MoU was inked.

"Russian oil was never sanctioned, only some vessels, service providers, and certain other entities were sanctioned (by the US). But if you are purchasing from other entities, you can very well continue to buy... We are buying completely from the non-sanctioned entities," Gupta told *The Indian Express* Thursday.

He added that the non-sanctioned sources of Russian oil supplies were more than adequate to meet India's demand and supplies till August-end were already tied up, with

"Volumes are available, only the price fluctuates. At times it (Russian oil) even commands a premium, instead of (the usual) discount, but enough volumes are available. In fact, because Russian refineries got impacted (due to Ukrainian attacks), surplus Russian oil volume was available for exports," he said.

Ever since the Russia-Ukraine war broke out in February 2022, Russian crude usually traded at a discount as numerous countries, predominantly in the West, shunned Moscow's oil.

• DIMINISHING GAINS

AFTER THE June 17 US-Iran MoU, energy flows through the strait started recovering, with hope in the market that supplies through the chokepoint would normalise steadily

THE OPTIMISM led to a fall in oil prices. Discounts on Russian oil at Indian ports had also widened to over \$10 per barrel to benchmark Brent crude in early July, as per industry estimates

HOWEVER, THE recovery in energy flows from West Asia



lasted about three weeks, after which attacks on ships in the region resumed and tanker traffic crashed again

Highly import-dependent Indian refiners, however, were quick to step up their purchases of Russia's discounted barrels, catapulting Moscow to the position of New Delhi top source of crude within a few months. Before the Ukraine war, Russia was a peripheral oil supplier to India, with less than 2% share in India's oil import basket.

But amid the West Asia war, as vessel movements through the Strait of Hormuz — which usually accounted for a fifth of global oil flows — effectively came to a halt, refiners in India and even other parts of the world scrambled for oil from al-

ternative sources, leading to discount erosion and even premium on Russian oil.

After the June 17 US-Iran MoU, energy flows through the strait started recovering, with hope in the market that supplies through the chokepoint would normalise steadily.

The optimism led to a fall in oil prices; discounts on Russian oil at Indian ports had also widened to over \$10 per barrel to benchmark Brent crude in early July, as per industry estimates. However, the recovery in energy flows from West Asia lasted about three weeks, after which attacks on ships in the region re-

sumed and tanker traffic crashed again. Amid the West Asia crisis, as oil flows from the Gulf dried up, Russian crude became India's strongest energy security hedge.

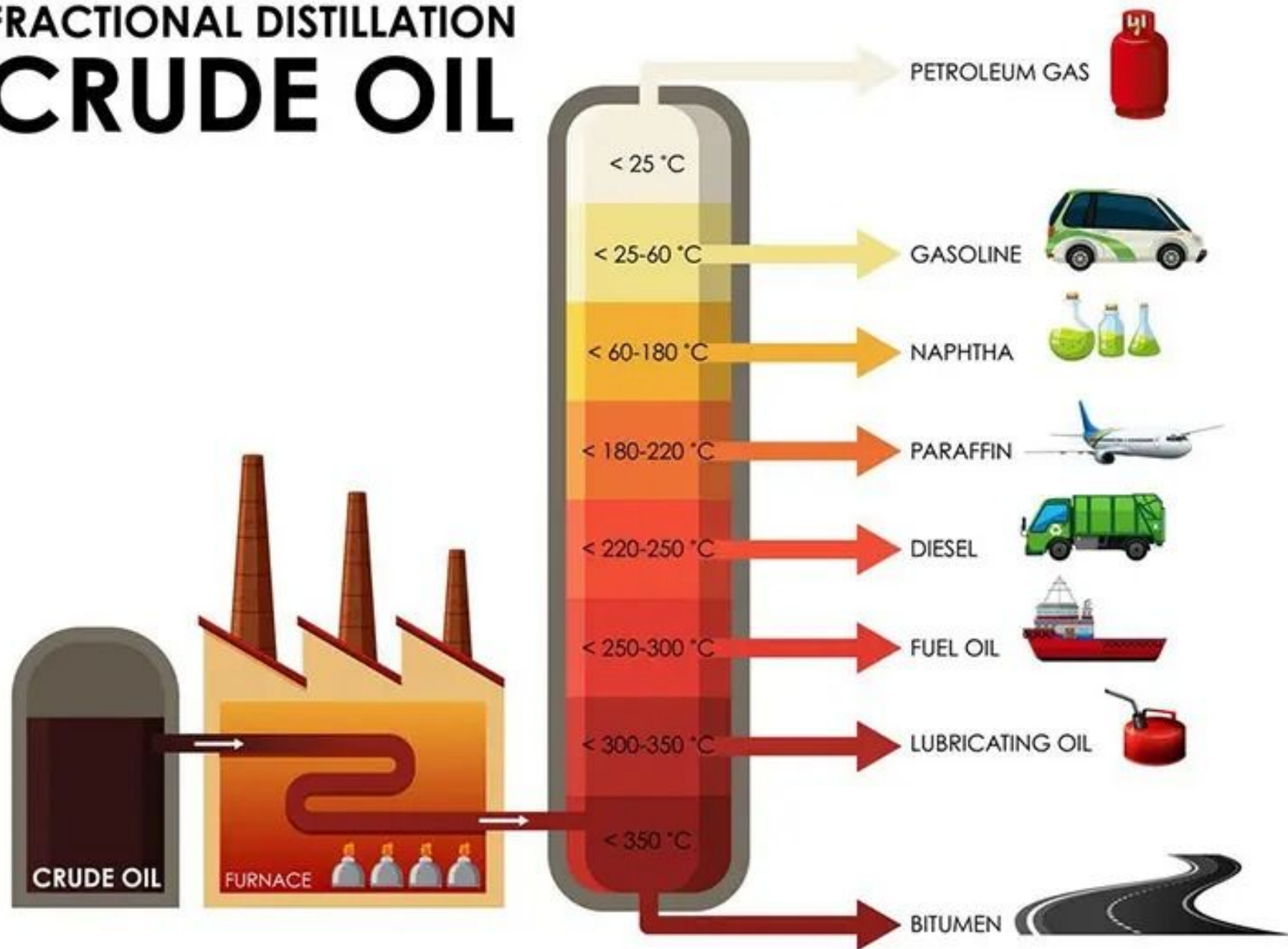
As per Kpler data, India's Russian oil imports rose to around 2.6 million barrels per day (bpd) in June, accounting for over half of New Delhi's total crude imports. July arrivals are also tracking at healthy levels and could match or even exceed June's volumes, as per estimates. India depends on imports to meet over 88% of its crude oil needs, and over 40% of that was met by oil that came via the Strait of Hormuz.

In the months preceding the West Asia war, oil imports from Russia had reduced notably as the US imposed sanctions on Russian oil majors Rosneft and Lukoil, and amid trade pact negotiations with New Delhi and Washington.

The US made a meaningful reduction in Russian oil imports a prerequisite for scrapping its 25% additional penal tariff on India. But as supplies from West Asia dwindled due to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz, Russian oil came to India's aid and volumes surged to historic highs.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

FRACTIONAL DISTILLATION CRUDE OIL



Renewed War Erases Russian Oil Discounts

Crude oil is a black liquid found in geological formations. It is a fossil fuel, which means it is formed from dead organisms that are buried under intense heat and pressure.

But not all crudes are alike. There are three primary qualities that differentiate one oil from another: Weight, Sweetness, and TAN count.

Weight of Crude: Light Oil vs Heavy Oil

Heavy oil: Evaporates slowly and Contains materials used to make products like asphalt

Light oil: Produces a greater percentage of gasoline and diesel and requires less processing

Based on Sulphur Content : Sweet or Sour Crude Oil

Sweet crude has very low levels of sulfur, well under 1%.

Sour crude has as much as 1-2% of sulfur.

Renewed War Erases Russian Oil Discounts

The three most well known regional benchmark oils are WTI, Brent, and OPEC.

- WTI stands for West Texas Intermediate. This is oil produced in the United States.
 - Typically lighter and Sweet
- Brent oil comes from the Scottish Brent and Ninian Systems located in the North Sea.
 - Typically lighter and Sweet
- OPEC stands for “Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries.” It is a collective group of crude oils from several countries including Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Kuwait, Iran, Libya, Nigeria, Republic of the Congo, Equatorial Guinea, Gabon, and Venezuela.
 - Venezuela crude is among the heaviest and most sulfurous in the world
- Urals oil is a reference oil brand used as a basis for pricing of the Russian export oil mixture. It is a mix of heavy sour oil of the Urals and the Volga region with light oil of Western Siberia.

Renewed War Erases Russian Oil Discounts

- **India's Crude Oil Import Dependence**

- **India imports over 85% of its crude oil requirements, making energy security a central concern of its foreign and economic policy**

- **Diversification of import sources across Russia, Gulf states, the US, and Africa is a key strategy to manage price volatility and supply disruption risk**

Renewed War Erases Russian Oil Discounts

The term 'West Texas Intermediate', sometimes found in news, refers to a grade of

This question was previously asked in

**UPSC Civil Services Exam
(Prelims) GS Official Paper-I...**

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1. Crude oil

2. Bullion

3. Rare earth elements

4. Uranium

Renewed War Erases Russian Oil Discounts

QUESTION

GS

Hard

Economy

Prelims 2011

In the context of global oil prices, “Brent crude oil” is frequently referred to in the news.

What does this term imply?

1. It is a major classification of crude oil.
2. It is sourced from the north sea.
3. It does not contain sulphur.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

[Select an option to attempt](#)

☐ A 2 only.

☐ B 1 and 2 only.

☐ C 1 and 3 only.

☐ D 1,2, and 3.

Centre Sacks 47 NTA Officials, Tightens Law to Tackle Paper Leaks

Centre sacks 47 NTA officials, tightens law to tackle paper leaks

Maitri Porecha
Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

In a move to crack down on exam malpractices, the Centre has taken a slew of actions, including strengthening the anti-paper leak law and terminating the services of up to 47 officials in the National Testing Agency (NTA).

The Union Cabinet on Friday cleared a proposal to introduce amendments to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, endowing the anti-paper leak law with tougher penalties and time-bound trial mechanisms.

Sources in the Ministry of Education said that the NTA had terminated 47 officials from their services. "Legal and criminal actions will also be taken against some of these officials. More reformatory actions will follow. This is

SC seeks govt's response on NEET reforms

NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday indicated that it would closely monitor the proposed overhaul of the NEET and directed the government to file a detailed response on whether it intends to shift the NEET-UG exam to a computer-based test and the safeguards it proposes to put in place. » **PAGE 11**

part of a complete overhaul of the NTA that has been in controversy over paper leaks," a source said. The proposed amendments to the anti-cheating law include steeper jail sentences, higher financial penalties and setting up of fast-track courts for speedy trials.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

Centre sacks 47 NTA officials, tightens law

The policy shift comes on the heels of a late-night video address by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who stated that stringent action would be taken against the paper leak mafia.

Imprisonment for those involved in organised examination fraud has been hiked from the previous 3-5 year bracket to 5 to 10 years in prison. Maximum fines for those involved in organised racket have been hiked up to ₹10 crore.

The law gives statutory backing to set up dedicated fast-track courts empowered to expedite cases. Fast-track courts will be mandated to conclude investigations, dispose of cases, and pronounce judgments within three months, the sources said. The original Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 was officially brought into force on June 21, 2024, amid widespread outrage over alleged malpractices in national exams such as NEET and UGC-NET.

Centre Sacks 47 NTA Officials, Tightens Law to Tackle Paper Leaks

- **National Testing Agency (NTA)**

- An **autonomous body under the Ministry of Education, established in 2017**, to conduct entrance examinations for higher education institutions, including NEET-UG for medical admissions and various UGC-NET and engineering entrance tests

- **Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024**

- India's first dedicated law to criminalise organised cheating and paper leaks in public examinations, brought into force on June 21, 2024, amid widespread outrage over alleged malpractices in NEET and UGC-NET
 - Covers offences like leakage of question papers, tampering with computer networks or servers, and impersonation, with provisions for both individuals and organised rackets

Like Children, Elderly Too Need State-Led Care Mechanism: HC

Like children, elderly too need State-led care mechanism: HC

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Taking note of increasing litigation related to the violation of the rights of senior citizens, the High Court of Karnataka has directed the State to examine the feasibility of creating a comprehensive policy or legislative framework for “senior citizens in need of care and protection”, broadly modelled on the lines of protection given to minors through the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015.

Mysuru incident

The court also directed the Mysuru district administration to admit a 74-year-old woman, suffering from gangrene and age-related ailments, and who was not taken care of by her children, to a government hospital and to provide her



Court asks Karnataka to study whether current laws protect dignity of elderly citizens.

with all necessary treatment and care at the cost of the government.

Justice Suraj Govindaraj passed the order while was hearing a petition filed by the woman’s 38-year-old son, who had challenged an order passed by the Assistant Commissioner, Mysuru, in favour of his mother on issues related to her maintenance.

During the hearing, the court noted that many pe-

titions involving neglect, abandonment, abuse, exploitation, deprivation of maintenance, denial of residence, unlawful deprivation of property, lack of medical care, absence of institutional support and other circumstances affecting their dignity, safety and well-being have been filed.

Following this, the court directed the State government to examine whether the existing statutory framework under the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Seniors Act, 2007, adequately addresses all such situations or whether additional executive, policy or legislative measures are required to identify and extend to the senior citizens required extended measures relating to rescue, protection, shelter, healthcare, and community-based care, on the lines of the provisions in the JJ Act, 2015.

Like Children, Elderly Too Need State-Led Care Mechanism: HC

Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007

Defintion

- "children" includes son, daughter, grandson and granddaughter but does not include a minor
 - "maintenance" includes provision for food, clothing, residence and medical attendance and treatment
 - "parent" means father or mother whether biological, adoptive or step father or step mother, as the case may be, whether or not the father or the mother is a senior citizen
 - "senior citizen" means any person being a citizen of India, who has attained the age of sixty years or above
-
- Applies when the senior citizen is unable to maintain themselves from their own earnings or property.
 - Legal responsibility - Places legal responsibility on children/relatives (legal heirs) to provide financial support, food, clothing, residence, and medical care.
 - Tribunals
 - Maintenance Tribunals - To hear petitions from senior citizens.
 - Appellate Tribunals - To hear appeals against the tribunal orders.
 - The maximum maintenance allowance shall not exceed Rs.10,000 per month.

Alongside Centre, States' Education Expenditure Too Declined Over Past 12 Years

Alongside Centre, states' education expenditure too declined over past 12 years



**GRAPHS,
DATA,
PERSPECTIVES**
BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

THE ONGOING youth protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi and in several other cities, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and seeking education reforms, have brought attention to the state of education in India.

The *Indian Express* had recently explained how the Education Ministry's share of the Union Budget had sharply declined over the past 12 years — from 4.6% in 2013-14 (the last year that the Congress-led UPA government was in power) to 2.5% in 2025-26. The fall suggests that the BJP-led NDA government reduced emphasis on education.

As a subject of policymaking, however,

education is not the sole preserve of the Union government.

Common subject

Education falls under the Concurrent list in the Seventh Schedule of the Indian Constitution.

The schedule essentially divides powers and responsibilities between the Union and state governments through three lists — Union, State and Concurrent. Both the Centre and state governments can legislate on subjects under the Concurrent list.

So, how do states act on the subject of education and what policy significance do they attach to it? A broad marker of priority is to examine the share of a state's total expenditure on education. The table and chart alongside provide a glimpse of where things stand.

Apart from providing an average for all states and Union Territories, the table also looks at a selection of states to provide a geographically and politically diverse sample for the country.

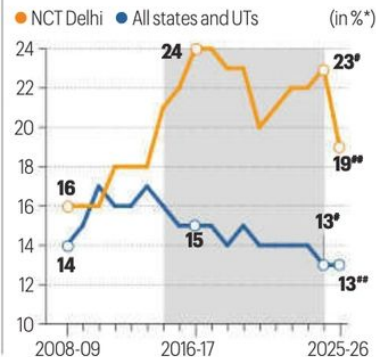
• State of education expenditure

State/Union Territory	Expenditure on education (2025-26)*	State-wise gross enrolment ratio (2024-25)**
Bihar	20	45
Gujarat	13	61
Kerala	12	94
Tamil Nadu	12	89
West Bengal	14	75
NCT Delhi	19	92
All states and UTs	13	69

*AS PERCENTAGE OF AGGREGATE EXPENDITURE **FOR SECONDARY EDUCATION *2024-25 (RE) **2025-26 (BE) SOURCE: RBI
NOTE: INCLUDES EXPENDITURE ON SPORTS, ART AND CULTURE UNDER REVENUE EXPENDITURE AND CAPITAL OUTLAY

For some context about the status of education, while many variables could be

• AAP effect on education spend



chosen, the table shows data on gross enrolment ratio (GER) at the secondary edu-

cation level (Classes 9 to 12). The GER is the total number of students enrolled in a specific level of education — regardless of their age — divided by the total population of the official age group for that level, multiplied by 100. A look at the GER in the second column confirms the long-held notions of which states are better educated and which are laggards.

For instance, Bihar's GER is 45 while that of Kerala is 94. A low GER also reveals the distance any state has to cover to achieve a better level of education. This is especially relevant given the population difference in states such as Bihar and Kerala. In essence, it gives a sense of the need for the state government to spend on education.

The first column in the table shows states' expenditure on education as a percentage of total expenditure. Bihar and Delhi stand out.

To be sure, both states were spending even higher than this in the years preceding 2025-26. In the same period, states such as Kerala and Tamil Nadu have shares

below the national average. Longer-term data — going back to 2008-09 — shows that Tamil Nadu has largely tracked and then fallen just behind the national level. Kerala used to allocate a higher share than the national average until the Covid-19 year of 2020, and has lagged since then. Gujarat, too, has lagged behind the national average more often than not.

What is concerning is that the national average of all states and UTs itself has been trending down, as the chart alongside shows. After staying at around 17% in 2013-14, the average share of expenditure on education has gradually fallen. This fall is crucial, since it mirrors the fall in the share of money spent by the Union government as well.

There are exceptions to this trend, though. Take the Union Territory of Delhi under the Aam Aadmi Party government, which initially made health and education the key pillars of its pitch to voters. Between 2014-15 and 2024-25, education's share went up sharply, in contrast to the falling trend of the national average.

Alongside Centre, States' Education Expenditure Too Declined Over Past 12 Years

● Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER)

○ The total number of students enrolled at a specific level of education, regardless of age, divided by the total population of the official age group for that level, multiplied by 100 a standard indicator of access to education, though it doesn't capture quality or learning outcomes

● The Trend

○ The Education Ministry's share of the Union Budget has sharply declined over the past 12 years, from 4.6% in 2013-14, the last year of the Congress-led UPA government, to 2.5% in 2025-26 under the BJP-led NDA government

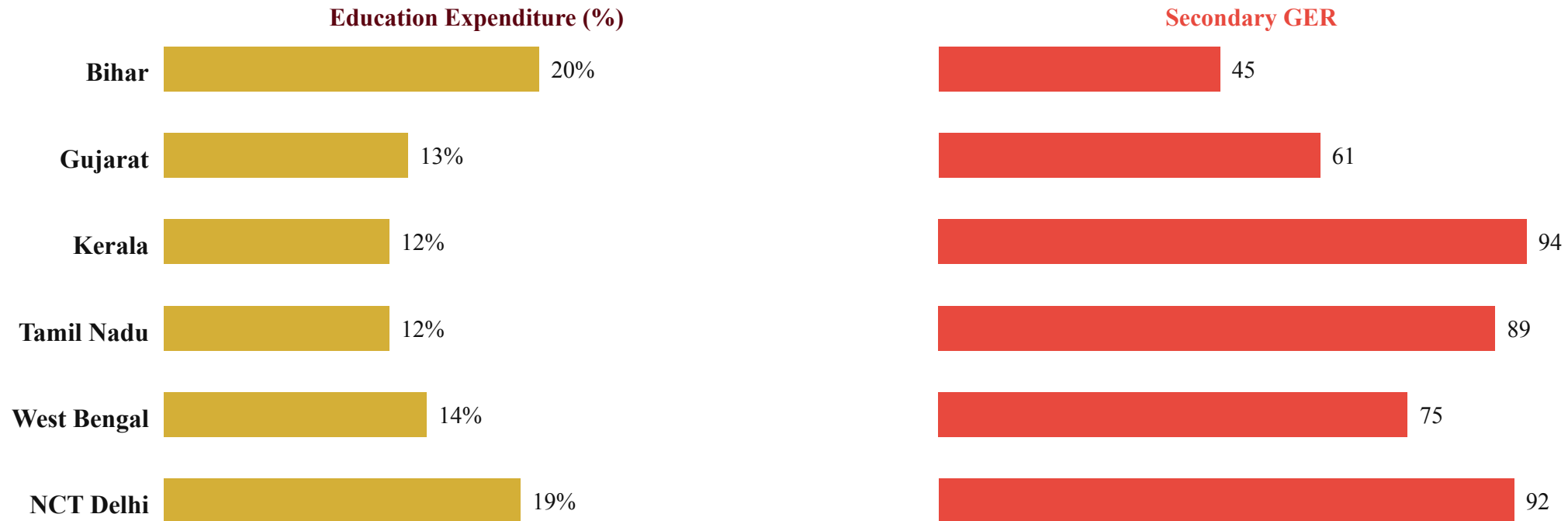
○ Education falls under the Concurrent List in the Seventh Schedule, so both the Centre and state governments can legislate and spend on it, prompting an examination of how states have responded

● Education Financing in India

○ The Kothari Commission (1966) recommended public expenditure on education reach 6% of GDP, a target India has consistently fallen short of; both Union and State budgetary allocations are tracked against this benchmark

Alongside Centre, States' Education Expenditure Too Declined Over Past 12 Years

Higher Spending Doesn't Always Mean Higher Enrolment



On Guard: The Dengue Vaccine Must Be Made Affordable to Those at Greatest Risk

On guard

The dengue vaccine must be made affordable to those at greatest risk

The CDSO's approval of the Qdenga dengue vaccine – the first in India's history – follows the vaccine's licensing in over 40 countries and a WHO prequalification, and some of the country's worst dengue years *vis-à-vis* the disease's burden, although that is evidence of better surveillance as well. The Aedes mosquitoes that spread the disease are expanding into semi-urban and rural districts, where conventional vector control is harder to sustain. The time to develop the vaccine itself is understandable. The four antigenically distinct dengue serotypes and the possibility of a 'second infection' by a different serotype producing more severe disease through antibody-dependent enhancement mean that an effective shot has to induce strong immunity against all four at once. This constraint nearly derailed the first licensed dengue vaccine, Dengvaxia, and the controversy in the Philippines in 2017 prompted greater regulatory caution. The design of Qdenga, by Japan-based Takeda, differs from that of Dengvaxia and, unlike the latter, can be administered without screening for a prior dengue infection.

Its protection against the serotypes varies from highest against DENV-2, followed by DENV-1, while uncertainty remains regarding protection against DENV-3 and DENV-4 in people without prior exposure to dengue. This is concerning because while DENV-2 is more common in India, DENV-3 prevalence is increasing. If the DENV-3 serotype dominates the 2026 monsoon season, Qdenga's impact could be substantially lower than anticipated, especially if many recipients are dengue-naïve. Qdenga also requires two doses across three months apart. Clinical data suggest that the first dose protects unevenly, with stronger evidence against DENV-1 and DENV-2 than DENV-3 and DENV-4. If a seronegative person takes the first shot on July 1, when the monsoon begins, and encounters DENV-3 in August, the shot may not suffice to prevent severe illness. Ensuring the highly mobile migrant workforce receives its second dose will be significantly difficult, too; those falling through the cracks may also be exposed to concerns raised in the TIDES trial of a 'negative efficacy' against hospitalisation related to DENV-3 among seronegative children. Finally, following Takeda's tiered pricing strategy worldwide, Qdenga may be too expensive for people living in dense urban slums with poor drainage. To ensure sufficient uptake among the populations at greatest risk, the government must negotiate a lower price. In the end, administering a dengue vaccine properly in a population is no less tricky than developing a vaccine against dengue, and the Qdenga rollout should give no cause for complacency.

On Guard: The Dengue Vaccine Must Be Made Affordable to Those at Greatest Risk

- **Dengue Fever**

- A mosquito-borne viral infection transmitted primarily by Aedes aegypti mosquitoes, endemic across India, especially during and after the monsoon; can range from mild fever to severe dengue haemorrhagic fever or shock syndrome

- This mosquito also transmits chikungunya, yellow fever and Zika infection.
 - QDENGGA is a recombinant, live-attenuated and tetravalent dengue vaccine designed to provide protection against all four dengue virus serotypes : DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 and DENV-4.

Thank You